

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 11: Eclipse Rising

Day 42 Since Awakening - 05:47

The daily quest completion notification faded as Hayami finished their twenty-kilometer run. Nineteen consecutive days of doubling the requirements. The routine had become meditative—their body moved on autopilot while their mind processed strategy and technique.

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!] [ACHIEVEMENT: BEYOND THE LIMIT] (19 days in a row) [+3 to all stats] [Random Reward Box obtained!] [Premium Reward Box obtained!]

Hayami checked their inventory: **[8 Premium Reward Boxes]**

Eight boxes. They'd been accumulating steadily, waiting for the right moment. But looking at the collection, Hayami realized they were hoarding them out of caution rather than strategy. The legendary boxes from the Basilisk fight had shown that the System's rewards were always relevant to their current needs.

Maybe it was time to trust that pattern.

They decided to open three boxes, leaving five in reserve for emergencies.

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX #1]

[CONTENTS:]

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: MANTLE OF THE STORM] [Description: A shoulder cape infused with wind and lightning essence] [+10 Agility, +10 Intelligence] [Passive: Storm's Grace - Movement speed increased by 15%. Lightning and Wind attacks deal 20% additional damage] [Passive: Aerodynamic - Reduce falling damage by 90%. Can glide short distances by manipulating wind] [Active Skill: Storm Dash - Burst of speed combining wind and lightning. Move up to 50 meters instantly. Cost: 150 Mana. Cooldown: 1 minute]

The mantle materialized—a flowing half-cape that attached to the left shoulder, colored in swirling patterns of blue-white and gray. It complemented their existing equipment perfectly, and the stats were excellent. More importantly, it enhanced two of their elements.

Hayami equipped it immediately, feeling the wind respond more eagerly to their will.

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX #2]

[CONTENTS:]

[CONSUMABLE ACQUIRED: STAT ENHANCEMENT POTION (PERMANENT) x2] [Effect:

Permanently increases all stats by +3. Single use each.]

[ITEM ACQUIRED: SKILL ENHANCEMENT STONE (GREATER) x2] [Effect: Increases proficiency of one skill by 25%. Single use each.]

Two permanent stat potions. Two greater enhancement stones. Hayami used both potions immediately, feeling the familiar warmth of stat increases flowing through their body.

[ALL STATS +6] (from both potions)

The greater enhancement stones went into inventory for later—they'd use one on Wind Manipulation once they pushed it closer to C-rank.

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX #3]

[CONTENTS:]

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: RING OF ELEMENTAL UNITY] [Description: A ring that harmonizes multiple elements within the wearer] [+8 to all stats] [Passive: Elemental Synergy - When using multiple elements simultaneously, mana cost reduced by 20%] [Passive: Unity - All elemental proficiency gains increased by 10%] [Active Skill: Element Swap - Instantly switch your dominant element focus. Enhances chosen element by 30% for 1 minute. Cost: 100 Mana. Cooldown: 2 minutes]

Perfect for their multi-element fighting style. Hayami equipped it on their other hand, opposite the Mana Regeneration Ring.

They checked their updated stats:

[STATS] (with all equipment including new items)

- Strength: 127 (base 69 + 44 equipment + 10% class + 4 from potions)
- Agility: 165 (base 65 + 61 equipment + 10% class + 15% trait + 4 from potions)
- Vitality: 117 (base 61 + 39 equipment + 10% class + 4 from potions)
- Intelligence: 182 (base 81 + 56 equipment + 10% class + 4 from potions)
- Sense: 132 (base 63 + 47 equipment + 10% class + 4 from potions)
- Mana: 2,320/2,320

[LEVEL: 27]

Intelligence pushing toward 200. Agility at 165. All stats comfortably in B-rank territory, with some approaching A-rank thresholds.

Three premium boxes opened, significant power increase, and they still had five boxes in reserve. Good enough.

Hayami showered, changed into their raid gear (which would appear as basic equipment to others thanks to Phantom Mode), and headed out to meet Himiko.

07:43 - Yokohama Station

Himiko was waiting at the designated meeting spot, bouncing slightly on her heels with nervous energy. She wore new combat gear—still basic by high-rank standards, but better than her first-raid equipment.

"Hey!" She waved enthusiastically. "Ready for our first guild raid?"

"Ready as I'll ever be." Hayami checked their phone. "Sato said to meet at the Gate checkpoint by 8 AM. We've got fifteen minutes."

They walked together through the morning crowds, Himiko chattering about the training she'd done yesterday—practicing her shapeshifting speed, working on maintaining forms under stress, experimenting with partial transformations.

"I can do just hands now," she said excitedly. "Like, keep my human body but give myself bird talons or wolf claws. Way more practical than full transformation for some situations."

"That's impressive. How's the mana cost?"

"Surprisingly low. Partial shifts are way more efficient than full transformations." Himiko grinned. "I might actually be getting good at this Hunter thing."

"You were always good at it. You just needed practice."

The Gate checkpoint came into view—Gate #YK-331, a C-rank designation with Eclipse Guild's banner flying beside the Association's. Significantly more organized than the independent party raids Hayami had done before.

Sato was already there with his team, plus three additional Hunters wearing Eclipse colors—backup support from the guild. When he saw Hayami and Himiko approach, his eyebrows rose.

"Amamiya. And you must be Nakayama." He extended his hand to Himiko. "Sato Kenji, party leader. Welcome to Eclipse's operation."

"Thanks for having me." Himiko shook his hand, her A-rank license visible on her chest drawing appreciative glances from the Eclipse Hunters.

Sato turned to Hayami. "New equipment? You're looking more professional every time I see you."

Hayami shrugged. "Saved up some money. Figured it was time to invest."

"Smart." Sato pulled up his tablet. "Alright, briefing. This is Frozen Depths, a C-rank Gate we've cleared twice before. Ice element dominant, expect Frost Wolves, Ice Elementals, and the boss is typically a Glacial Wurm. Standard formation—main combat team up front, you two on support and cleanup. Questions?"

One of the Eclipse Hunters—a stern-looking woman in her forties—spoke up. "The A-rank is support? Seems like a waste of her capabilities."

"She's Level 15 with minimal combat experience," Sato explained. "She's here to learn and practice, not carry the raid. We operate as a team, regardless of rank."

The woman nodded, satisfied. Professional approach. Hayami approved.

They entered the Gate.

**[NOTICE: You have entered a C-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Frozen Depths] [Estimated Difficulty: C]
[Recommended Level: 35-50]**

The temperature drop was immediate and brutal. Hayami's Elemental Adaptation Cloak absorbed 30% of the environmental effect, making it merely uncomfortable instead of dangerous. Himiko shifted her body slightly—probably adjusting her internal temperature through shapeshifting.

The Gate interior was a cavern system covered in ice, with frozen waterfalls creating natural pillars throughout. The light was strange—reflected and refracted through ice until everything glowed with cold blue luminescence.

"Formation!" Sato commanded. "Stay tight, watch for ambushes. Frost Wolves hunt in packs."

The first encounter came within five minutes—eight wolves, each the size of a small horse, with fur that looked like crystallized ice.

[FROST WOLF - LEVEL 36] x8 [HP: 3,800/3,800 each]

The Eclipse team engaged with practiced efficiency. Fire-element mages provided area damage, melee fighters used flame-enchanted weapons. The wolves fell quickly.

Two wolves broke through toward the support position. Hayami and Himiko reacted simultaneously—their practiced coordination showing immediately.

Himiko shifted into a larger wolf form, intercepting one. Hayami hit the other with Advanced Lightning Strike enhanced by Storm's Grace passive. The bolt punched through the wolf's skull, and it dissolved into mist.

[FROST WOLF DEFEATED] [+1,440 EXP]

Himiko's wolf form tore out her target's throat with brutal efficiency. She shifted back to human, barely winded.

Sato glanced back. "Nice work, support team. Keep that up."

They progressed through four chambers, clearing packs of Frost Wolves and Ice Elementals. The Eclipse team moved with military precision—coordinated attacks, efficient mana usage, constant communication. This was what professional guild operations looked like.

Hayami and Himiko fell into their practiced formations, handling stragglers and protecting the main team's flanks. By the third chamber, they were moving together like they'd been partners for months instead of days.

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 27 → LEVEL 28] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

The experience was accumulating steadily. Level 36 enemies gave good returns, and Hayami had killed at least twenty personally by the time they reached the boss chamber.

The entrance was massive—a natural cathedral of ice with a frozen lake in the center. And coiled in the middle of that lake was the Glacial Wurm.

Except something was wrong.

[GLACIAL WURM KING - LEVEL 52] [BOSS MONSTER - B-RANK] [HP: 68,000/68,000]

"B-rank?" one of the Eclipse Hunters said with alarm. "The report said C-rank boss!"

Sato's expression hardened. "Gates can evolve if they're not cleared frequently enough. This one must have upgraded." He assessed the situation quickly. "We can handle this. Formation Beta—mages focus on defense and support, melee creates openings, support team handles any adds that spawn. Everyone stays sharp."

The Glacial Wurm King was enormous—fifteen meters long, covered in scales that looked like polished sapphire ice, with eyes that glowed white-gold. When it roared, the entire cavern shook, and icicles fell from the ceiling like spears.

The battle began.

The Eclipse team fought with impressive coordination. Sato tanked with a tower shield, drawing the wurm's attention. The fire mages launched sustained flame attacks to weaken the ice scales. The melee fighters struck at joints and weak points with precision timing.

But a B-rank boss was a different beast from C-rank. The wurm's ice breath could freeze multiple Hunters solid. Its tail sweeps hit with enough force to crack bones even through armor. Its scales absorbed fire magic more effectively than expected.

Three minutes in, the Eclipse team was struggling. One melee fighter got clipped by the tail and went down hard. A mage took ice breath to the chest and barely survived thanks to defensive wards.

Then adds spawned—Ice Elementals, a dozen of them, pouring from cracks in the walls.

[ICE ELEMENTAL - LEVEL 38] x12

"Support team, handle the adds!" Sato bellowed, his voice strained. "We've got the boss!"

Hayami and Himiko moved.

"Formation Three!" Hayami called out. "Zone control!"

"On it!" Himiko shifted into various animal forms, using speed and agility to herd the Elementals toward one location.

Hayami raised both hands. "Lightning Domain!"

The hemisphere of crackling electricity appeared, and Himiko drove the Elementals into it. They took continuous damage, their ice forms melting under the sustained electrical assault.

But twelve Level 38 enemies was too many for the Domain alone. Hayami pulled Storm Fang and activated their new equipment. "Storm Dash!"

Wind and lightning combined, and suddenly they were moving at speeds that made Lightning Step look slow. They crossed the battlefield in a blur, Storm Fang carving through Elementals with lightning-enhanced strikes. The Mantle of the Storm's bonuses stacked with their other equipment, making each hit devastating.

[MULTIPLE ICE ELEMENTALS DEFEATED] [+17,280 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 28 → LEVEL 29]

Himiko provided support—shifting into forms that could block, distract, or deliver finishing blows. Their coordination was flawless. Within two minutes, all twelve adds were eliminated.

The Eclipse team was still struggling with the boss. The Glacial Wyrn King had dropped to about 40% health, but it was getting more aggressive. Its attacks were becoming wild, unpredictable, dangerous.

"We need more damage!" Sato shouted. "Mages, everything you've got!"

Hayami made a decision. They'd been holding back, not wanting to reveal too much. But the Eclipse team was good people—Sato had proven himself reliable, the guild Hunters were professional. And if the boss wasn't defeated soon, someone was going to die.

"Himiko, cover me!" Hayami called.

"What are you—"

Hayami didn't wait for the question. They activated Battle Meditation, feeling their mana regeneration double immediately. Then they channeled all three elements simultaneously—lightning, earth, wind—feeling the Elemental Harmony bonus stack to maximum.

"ELEMENTAL FUSION: THUNDER TEMPEST!"

Lightning and wind merged into a spiraling storm of electricity that roared across the chamber. The attack struck the Glacial Wurm King like a natural disaster, lightning bolts branching across its entire body while wind amplified the electrical currents.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [GLACIAL WYRM KING HP: 27,200 → 16,800]

Over ten thousand damage in one attack. The Eclipse team stared.

Hayami didn't stop. Storm Fang crackled with lightning as they activated Storm Dash again, closing the distance to the boss in a fraction of a second. Advanced Lightning Strike through the blade, aimed at the wurm's exposed underbelly.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [GLACIAL WYRM KING HP: 16,800 → 11,200]

The wurm thrashed, trying to dislodge Hayami. Sato recovered from his shock and rallied the team. "Focus fire! It's weakened! Bring it down!"

The combined assault—Eclipse's fire magic, melee strikes, and Hayami's relentless elemental attacks—finally overwhelmed the Glacial Wurm King. It collapsed with a final, mournful roar, its body already beginning to dissolve into mist.

[GLACIAL WYRM KING DEFEATED] [+10,400 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 29 → LEVEL 30]

[NOTICE: You have reached Level 30!] [New thresholds unlocked. Significant stat bonuses applied.]

Silence filled the chamber except for the sound of heavy breathing. The Eclipse team stood among the dissolving boss remains, processing what had just happened.

Then Sato turned to Hayami, his expression unreadable. "Amamiya. What the hell was that?"

"Lightning and wind fusion technique," Hayami said calmly. "Picked it up recently."

"That was B-rank damage output. Minimum." The stern Eclipse woman was staring. "You're E-rank. How?"

"Training." Hayami kept their voice casual. "A lot of training."

"And multiple elements," another Hunter added. "I saw lightning, earth, and wind. E-ranks don't have multiple elements."

Hayami shrugged. "The Association's assessment was at Awakening. I've been developing new abilities since then."

Sato's expression cycled through shock, confusion, and finally settled on something like resigned acceptance. "You know what? I've stopped trying to figure you out. You do impossible things every time I work with you." He shook his head with a slight smile. "Just... thanks. That fusion attack saved us. We were losing that fight."

"Team effort," Hayami deflected. "You kept it distracted, we finished it off."

The Eclipse team seemed willing to accept that explanation, though Hayami could see the questions in their eyes. But before anyone could press further, Himiko jumped in.

"Man, that was intense! First B-rank boss, right?" She was using her usual enthusiastic energy to redirect attention. "I'm still shaking! How do you all stay so calm during fights like that?"

The conversation shifted to safer topics—battle tactics, proper boss positioning, how to handle Gate evolution scenarios. The Eclipse Hunters were professionals; they had a job to complete, and standing around speculating about power levels wasn't productive.

They harvested the boss loot—rare materials, high-grade magic stones, and one exceptional drop: a B-rank ice crystal worth at least ¥2,000,000. Sato divided the loot according to guild protocol, with Hayami and Himiko each receiving their contracted payment plus a bonus share for exceptional combat contribution.

[PAYMENT RECEIVED: ¥200,000] [LOOT SHARE BONUS: ¥140,000] [TOTAL: ¥340,000]

More than they'd expected. The guild was generous with successful raids, especially ones that exceeded difficulty expectations.

13:26 - Outside the Gate

The Eclipse team dispersed after the payment distribution, most heading back to guild headquarters for debriefing. Sato pulled Hayami aside before leaving.

"Listen," he said quietly. "I don't know what you really are. E-rank, secret C-rank, whatever. But you're reliable, you're competent, and you don't cause problems." He handed Hayami a business card. "Eclipse is always looking for capable Hunters. If you ever want to join a guild officially, talk to me. We'd be happy to have you."

"Thanks. I'll think about it."

Sato nodded and left. Hayami pocketed the card—maybe guild membership would be useful eventually, but for now they preferred independence.

Himiko bounced over, grinning. "That was amazing! Did you see their faces when you used that fusion attack? Priceless!"

"You did a good job redirecting attention afterward."

"Well, yeah. You asked me not to draw attention to you." Himiko's expression became more serious. "Though I don't know how long you can keep the E-rank thing going. You're putting out B-rank damage. People are going to notice."

"I know." Hayami checked their phone—1:30 PM. Still early in the day. "Hey, want to hit the training gym? I need to work on wind proficiency, and it's better with a sparring partner."

"Sure! Though..." Himiko hesitated. "Are you going to show me your full capabilities? Because I've been training with you for days and I'm pretty sure you're still holding back."

"Maybe." Hayami started walking toward the station. "But you have to promise something."

"What?"

"Don't tell other Hunters about my real power level. Not even if they ask directly." Hayami met her eyes. "I need the low profile. The moment the Association realizes an E-rank has B-rank capabilities, they'll want to re-test me, investigate how it's possible, probably monitor me constantly. I don't need that attention."

Himiko nodded slowly. "I get it. Secret powerful E-rank training in the shadows. Very mysterious and cool." She grinned. "Your secret's safe with me. Though you might want to tone down the flashy attacks in public raids."

"Yeah, that was... more than I intended."

"You saved lives. The Eclipse team would have lost people if you hadn't gone all out." Himiko bumped her shoulder against Hayami's. "You did the right thing. Just maybe dial it back to like, 70% next time?"

"Noted."

They caught the train back to Tokyo, both tired but satisfied. A successful raid, good pay, minimal injuries, and their partnership had proven effective even in unexpectedly difficult situations.

15:12 - Hunter Training Gym

Hayami sealed the training room and immediately felt the difference as Phantom Mode deactivated inside the privacy wards. Their equipment's true appearance manifested—the Crown of the Arbiter gleaming with three elemental gems, the Mantle of the Storm flowing with wind and lightning, all their legendary gear visible in its full glory.

Himiko stared. "Okay, that's way more equipment than I thought you had. Is that a crown? You're wearing an actual crown?"

"It's called the Crown of the Arbiter. Legendary item. Enhances all my elements." Hayami pulled up their status window and shared it with Himiko.

[HAYAMI AMAMIYA - LEVEL 30] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 2)]

[STATS]

- Strength: 127
- Agility: 165
- Vitality: 117
- Intelligence: 182
- Sense: 132
- Mana: 2,320/2,320

[ABILITIES]

- Lightning Manipulation (C-Rank - 38%)
- Earth Manipulation (C-Rank - 15%)
- Wind Manipulation (D-Rank - 34%)

Himiko read through it twice, her expression cycling through disbelief, awe, and finally something like pride. "You hit Level 30. And your Intelligence is over 180. That's... Hayami, that's A-rank level for mages. Maybe high A-rank."

"Just in that one stat. My physical stats are still B-rank range."

"Still! You're a month old Hunter with A-rank mage stats!" Himiko laughed. "This is insane. You're insane. I'm friends with an insane person who's breaking every rule about Hunter progression."

"Is that a problem?"

"Are you kidding? It's awesome." Himiko shifted through several forms rapidly—excitement making her shapeshifting unstable. "Okay, so training. You want to work on wind, right? What do you need?"

"Practice using it in combat. I can manipulate it fine in isolation, but integrating it with lightning and earth in real-time is harder." Hayami generated wind currents around their hand. "The three elements have different rhythms. Lightning wants to discharge immediately, earth wants to settle and solidify, wind wants to flow and disperse. Making them work together requires constant adjustment."

"So you need someone to fight while you practice the adjustment." Himiko cracked her knuckles. "I can do that. And hey, this time you don't have to hold back. I want to see what you can really do."

They spent three hours sparring at full intensity. Hayami used all three elements freely, experimenting with combinations and transitions. Wind to enhance movement, then lightning for attack, then earth for defense. Shifting between elements mid-combat, finding the flow that made them work together naturally.

Himiko pushed them hard—shifting forms constantly, attacking from unexpected angles, forcing Hayami to adapt. Her A-rank physical stats meant she could actually challenge them, creating genuine pressure that helped their training.

By the end, Hayami was exhausted but satisfied.

[WIND MANIPULATION: D-Rank (34% → 52%)]

Eighteen percent gain in one training session. The Elemental Awakening Elixir from earlier plus the Ring of Elemental Unity's 10% proficiency boost was accelerating their progress significantly.

"That was incredible," Himiko said, transforming back to human form and collapsing on the training room floor. "You're like... watching you is like watching someone play a strategy game in real-time. Constant adaptation, always three moves ahead."

"Combat Analysis skill. Legendary passive I got from the Hunter Killer title." Hayami sat down beside her. "It helps with predicting and responding."

"Show-off." Himiko grinned. "But seriously, thank you for letting me train with you. Seeing you use multiple elements like that, watching how you transition between them—it's helping me understand my own shapeshifting better. Like, the principle is the same, right? Managing different states, transitioning smoothly, using what's appropriate for the situation."

"That's a good observation. Your shapeshifting is basically physical element manipulation."

"Exactly!" Himiko sat up excitedly. "And if I apply the same principles you use for elemental combat—preparation, smooth transitions, knowing when to shift—I can probably get way better at combat shapeshifting."

They talked strategy for another hour, sharing insights and techniques. The training had been valuable for both of them—Hayami improving their wind integration, Himiko developing better combat instincts.

As they left the gym, Himiko's phone buzzed. She checked it and smiled. "My brother wants to meet for dinner. Family stuff. Rain check on post-training food?"

"No problem. Go see your family."

"Thanks. And Hayami?" Himiko's expression became serious. "I meant what I said. Your secret's safe with me. Whatever you're doing, however you're getting this strong—I've got your back."

"Same to you."

They parted ways at the station, and Hayami headed home. The apartment felt smaller now, filled with equipment and training materials. Maybe it was time to look at bigger places. With over ¥1,100,000 in savings, they could afford something better.

But that was a decision for another day.

Hayami checked their updated status one more time:

[LEVEL: 30] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 2)] [ELEMENTS MASTERED: 2/7] [DAYS SINCE AWAKENING: 42]

[TOTAL FINANCES: ¥1,187,000]

[PREMIUM BOXES REMAINING: 5] [RANDOM BOXES REMAINING: 5]

Six weeks since Awakening. Level 30. Three elements. A-rank level mage stats. B-rank overall capability. A reliable partner. Financial stability. Recognition from a professional guild.

The decision not to buy a new weapon had been correct. The System provided better equipment than money could buy. Trust the grind. Trust the process. Trust that the path would continue to unfold.

Hayami set an alarm for 5 AM and went to sleep, the Crown of the Arbiter pulsing gently on their nightstand.

Tomorrow would bring another daily quest. Another step forward. Another day of becoming stronger.

The grind continued.

[END OF CHAPTER 11]